

NATURE STUDY JOURNAL

A Charlotte Mason Inspired Outdoor Learning Guide

Observe. Sketch. Wonder. Learn.

By Daniel Tesfamariam

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HOW TO DO NATURE STUDY

Charlotte Mason believed that children learn best through direct contact with the natural world. Nature study is not about textbooks - it is about stepping outside and truly SEEING what is around you.

THE PRACTICE IS SIMPLE:

1. Go outside regularly (aim for weekly, same location if possible)
2. SIT QUIETLY for the first 5 minutes - just observe
3. Choose ONE thing to study closely (a leaf, insect, cloud, rock)
4. SKETCH what you see (skill does not matter - observation does)
5. RECORD details: color, size, texture, behavior, habitat
6. RESEARCH what you found when you return home
7. Keep this journal as your growing record of discovery

TIPS FOR SUCCESS:

- Bring a magnifying glass to notice small details
- Go at different times of day (dawn, midday, dusk)
- Visit the same spot across seasons to notice changes
- Let your child lead - follow THEIR curiosity
- There are no wrong observations
- Silence is part of the practice (resist filling every moment with talk)
- Bring field guides if you want to identify species
- A camera can supplement sketching but should not replace it

WHAT YOU NEED:

- This journal and a pencil (colored pencils optional)
- Magnifying glass
- Comfortable outdoor clothing
- A willing heart to slow down and notice

SPRING OBSERVATIONS

What to look for during spring:

- Birds returning from migration (listen for new songs)
- First flowers blooming (crocuses, daffodils, dandelions)
- Tree buds opening - notice the stages
- Insects emerging (bees, butterflies, ants becoming active)
- Rain patterns and puddle ecosystems
- Nesting behavior - birds gathering materials
- Longer days - track sunrise/sunset times
- Seed sprouting - plant something and observe daily
- Frog/toad activity near water
- Weeds - identify 5 common spring weeds in your area

MY SPRING GOALS:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Favorite spring discovery this year:

SUMMER OBSERVATIONS

What to look for during summer:

- Full canopy - compare leaf shapes from different trees
- Garden visitors - identify insects on plants
- Cloud formations (cumulus, stratus, cirrus)
- Night sky - visible constellations, moon phases
- Water life - pond study, stream inhabitants
- Heat effects - observe how plants and animals adapt
- Fruit and berry development on plants
- Spider webs - early morning with dew is best
- Lightning bugs / fireflies at dusk
- Rock and mineral study - visit a creek bed

MY SUMMER GOALS:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Favorite summer discovery this year:

FALL OBSERVATIONS

What to look for during fall:

- Leaf color changes - collect and press specimens
- Migration patterns - flocks of birds heading south
- Seed dispersal methods (wind, animal, water)
- Mushrooms and fungi appearing
- Squirrel behavior (gathering, burying)
- Shorter days - track the changing light
- First frost - observe what happens to plants
- Harvest observations - visit farm or garden
- Deciduous vs evergreen - compare preparations
- Animal tracks in mud after rain

MY FALL GOALS:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Favorite fall discovery this year:

WINTER OBSERVATIONS

What to look for during winter:

- Bare tree silhouettes - compare branch patterns
- Bird identification (easier without leaves blocking view!)
- Animal tracks in snow
- Evergreen study - types of needles and cones
- Ice formations - icicles, frozen puddles, frost patterns
- Winter sky - stars are brighter in cold air
- Dormant plants - what is happening underground?
- Bird feeder observations (species, behavior, hierarchy)
- Weather patterns - wind direction, cloud types
- Signs of life persisting through cold

MY WINTER GOALS:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Favorite winter discovery this year:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #1

Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #2

Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #3

Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #4

Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #5

Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #6

Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #7

Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #8

Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #9

Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #10

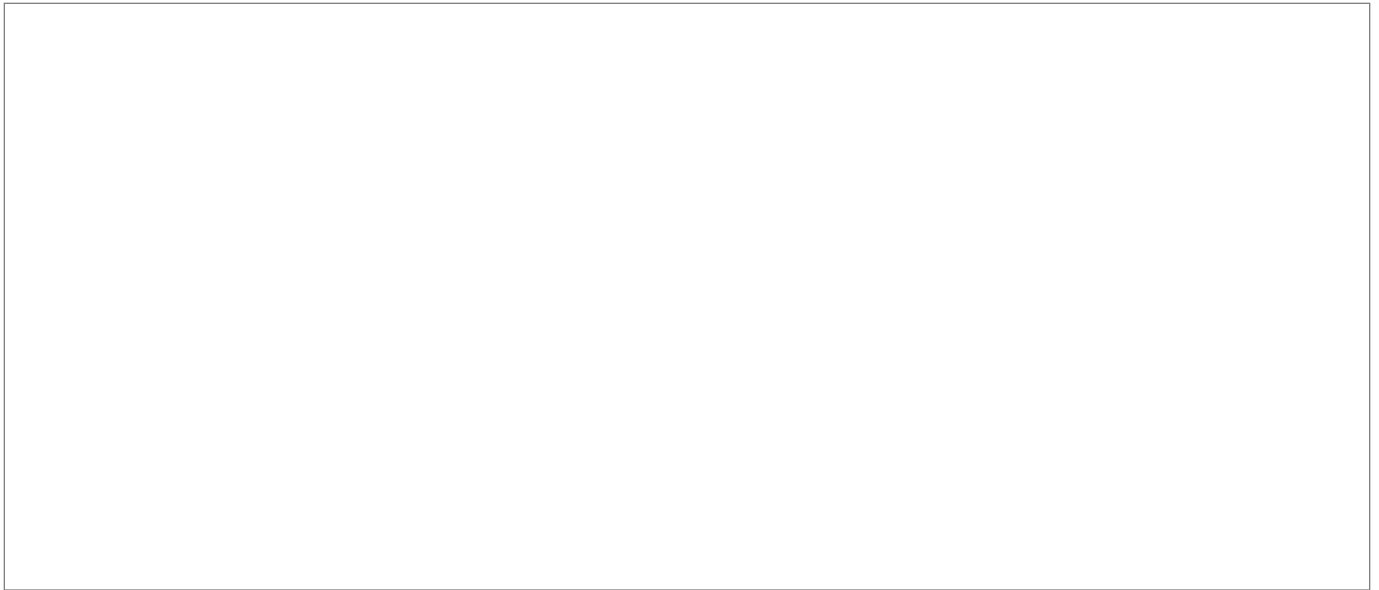
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #11

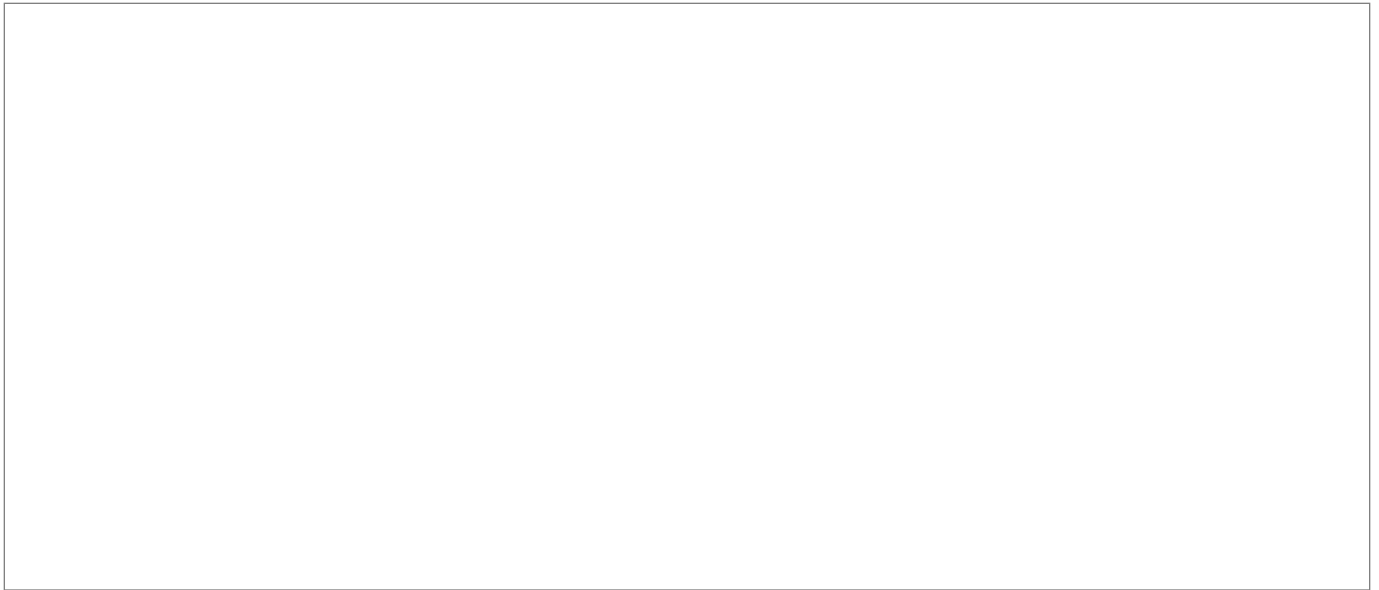
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #12

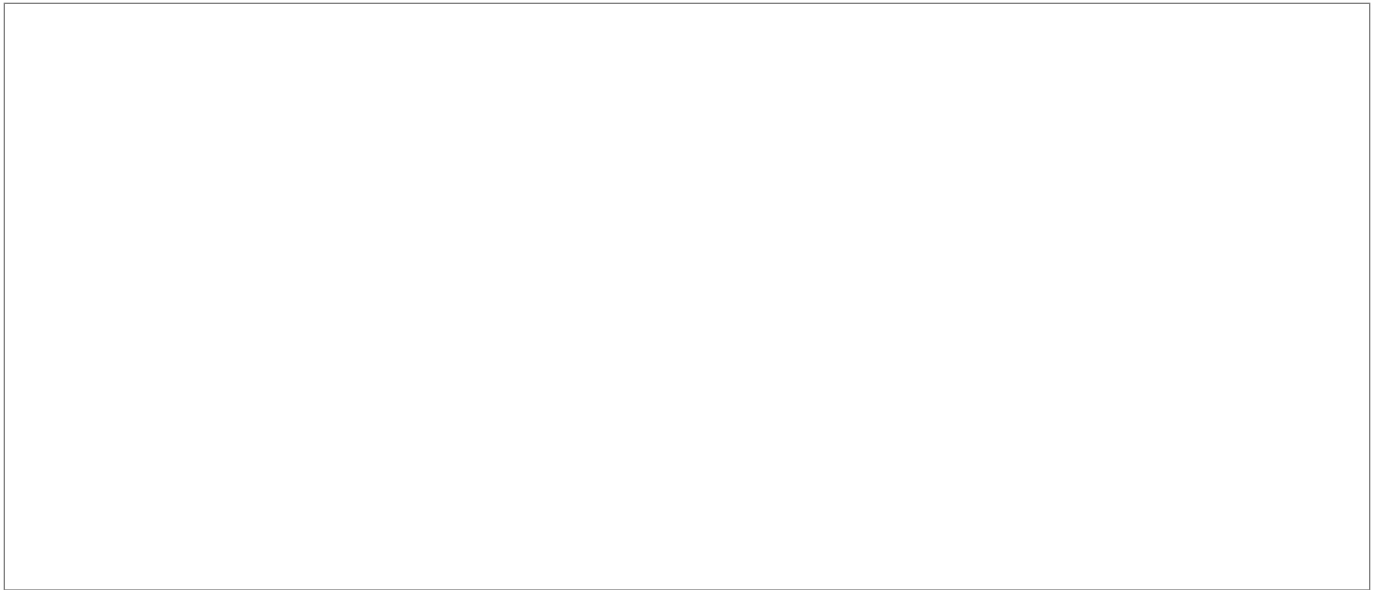
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #13

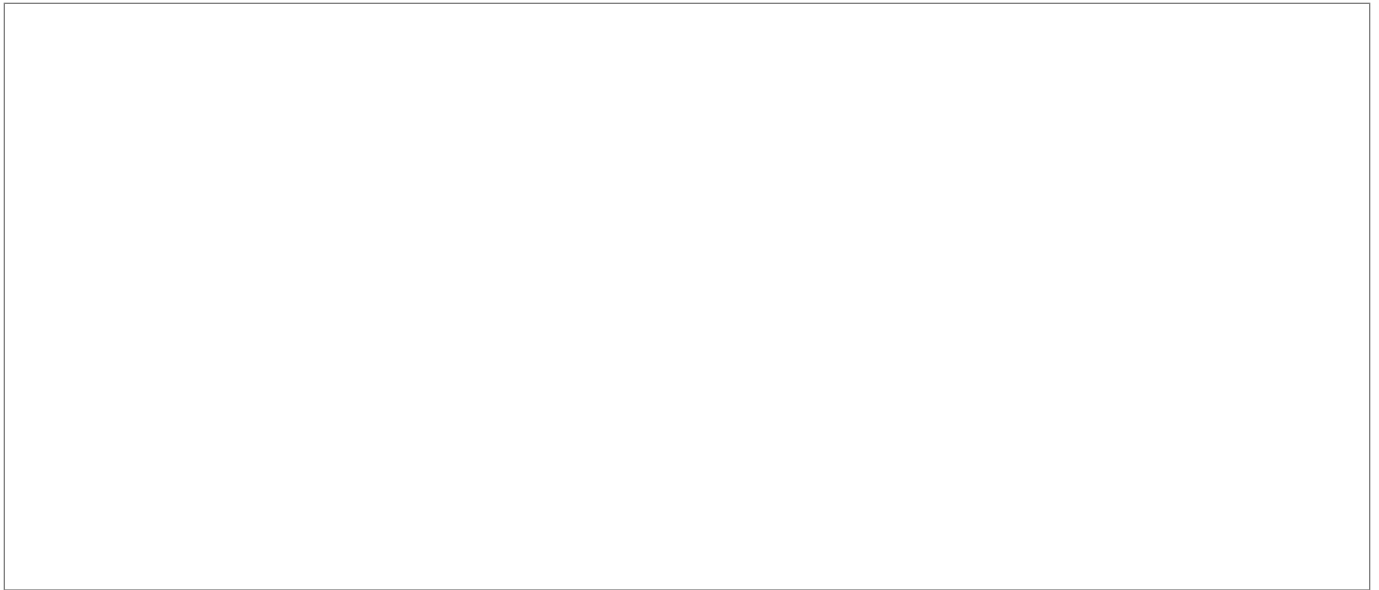
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #14

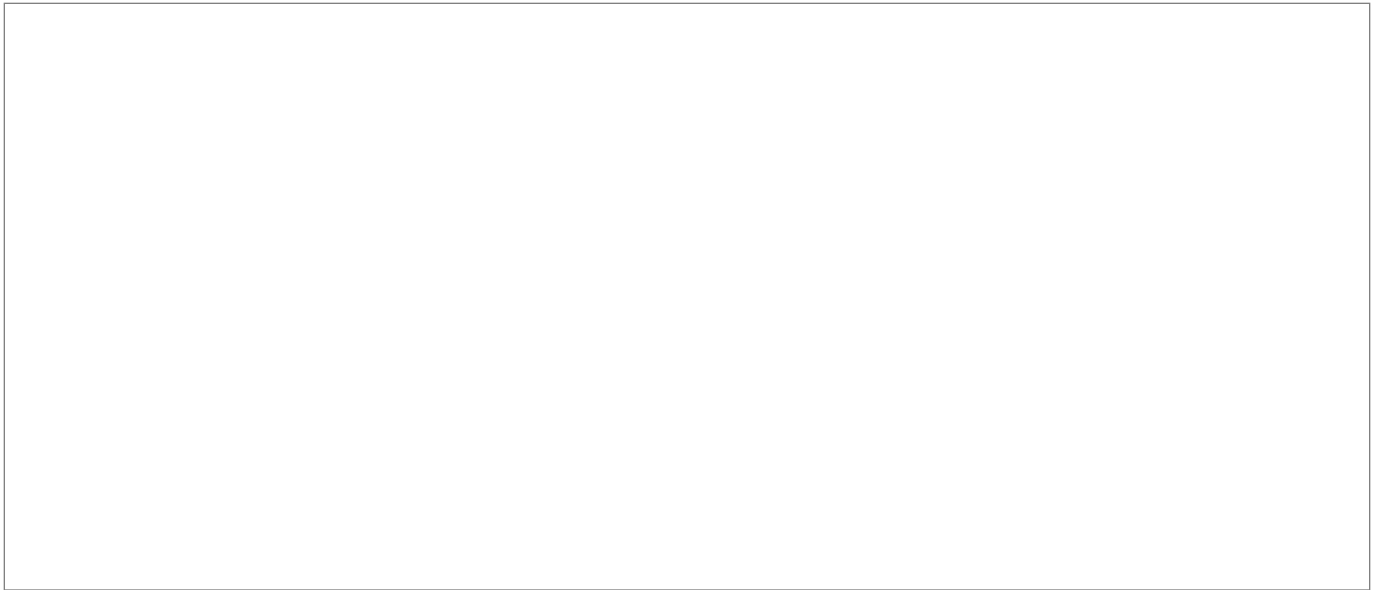
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #15

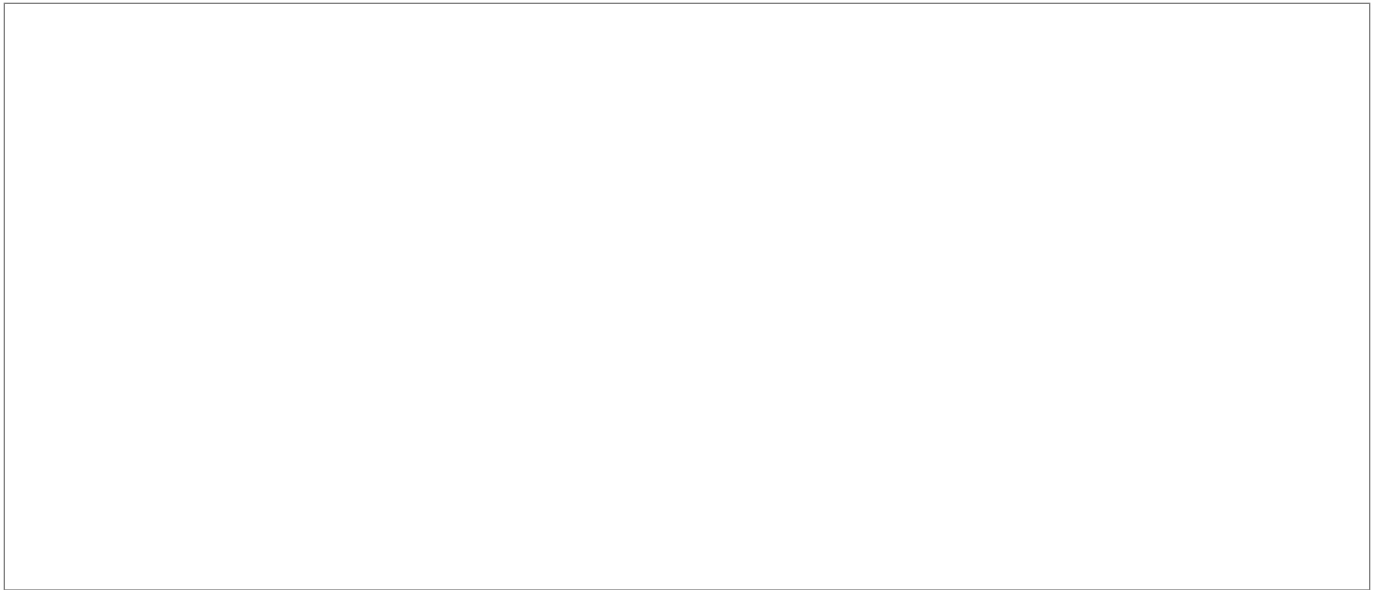
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #16

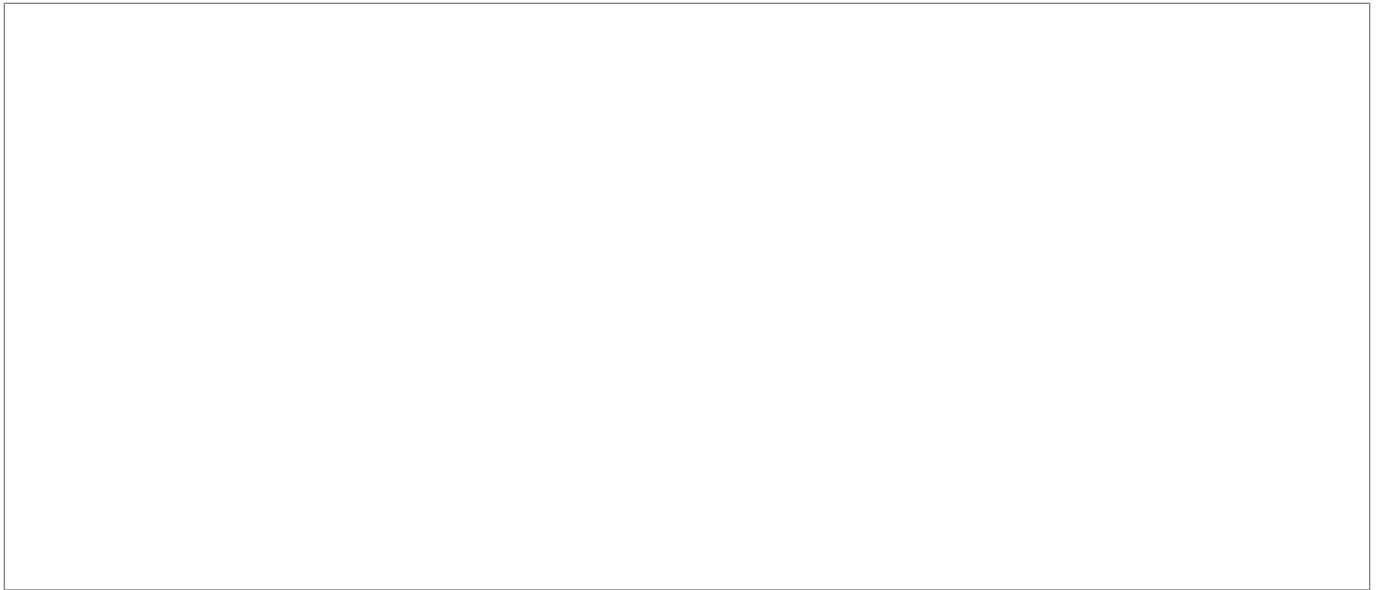
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #17

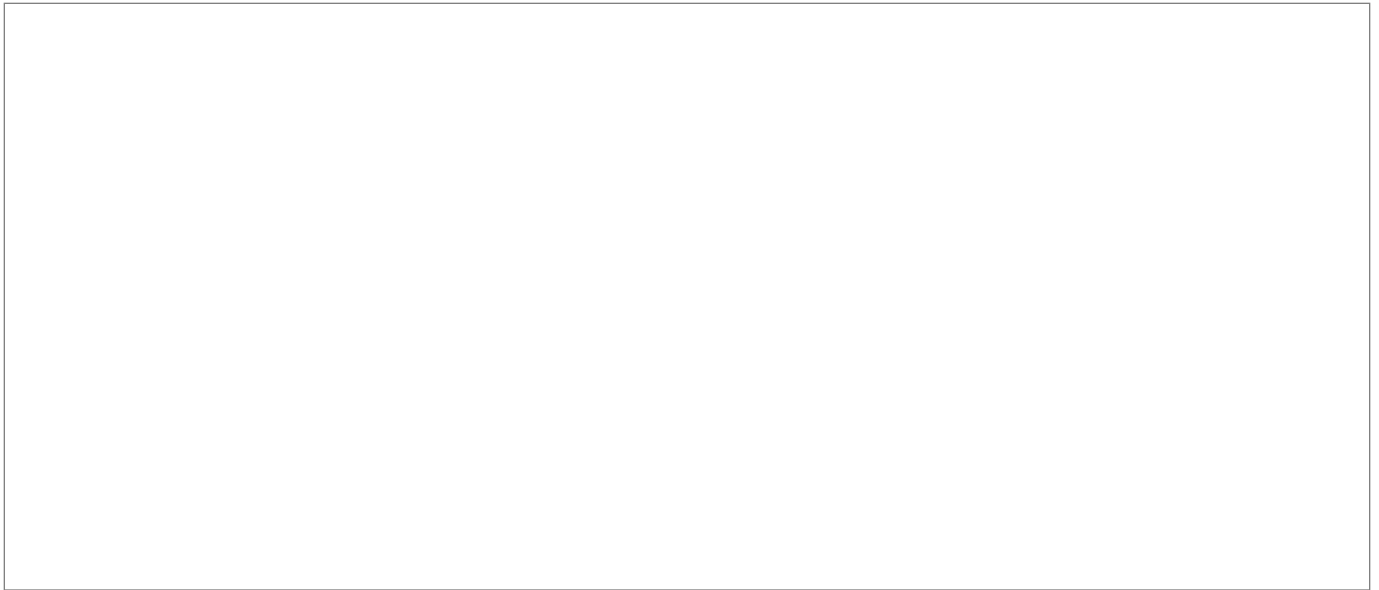
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #18

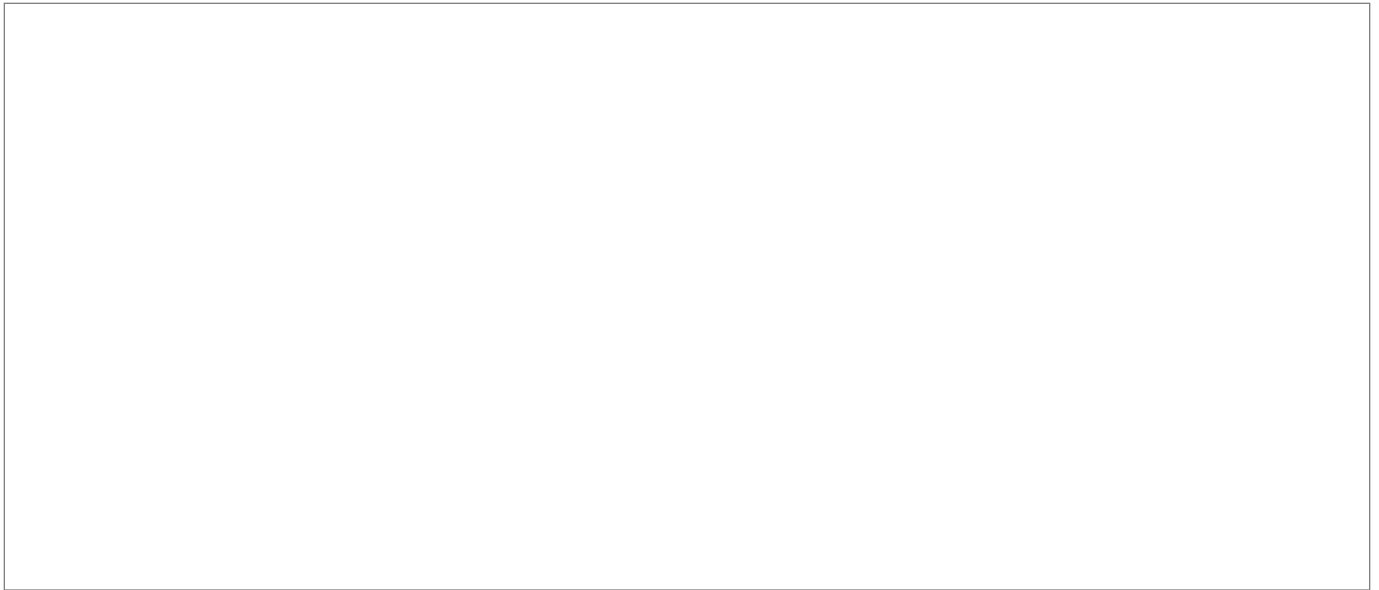
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #19

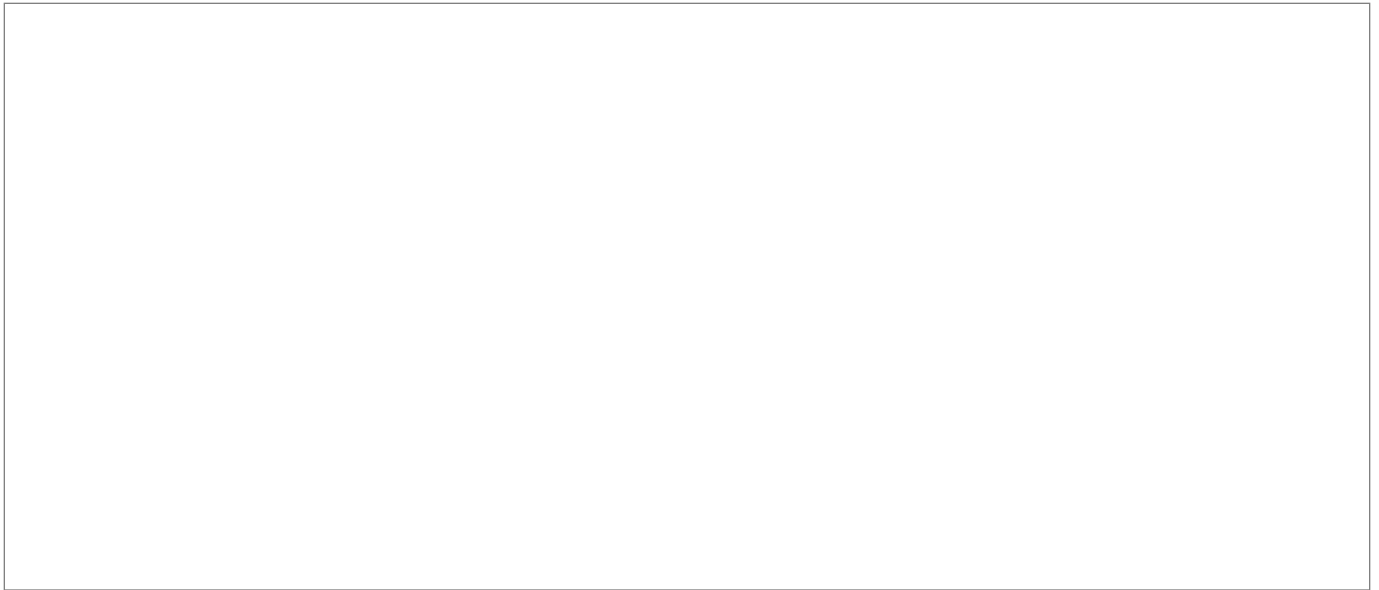
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #20

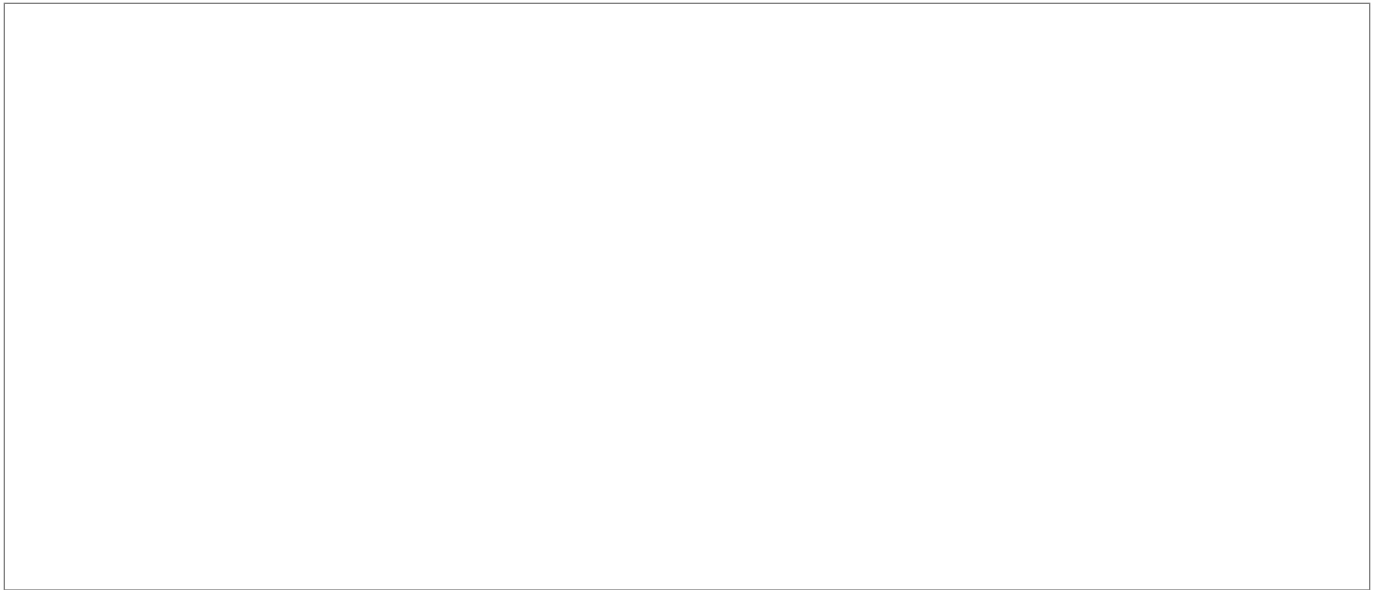
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #21

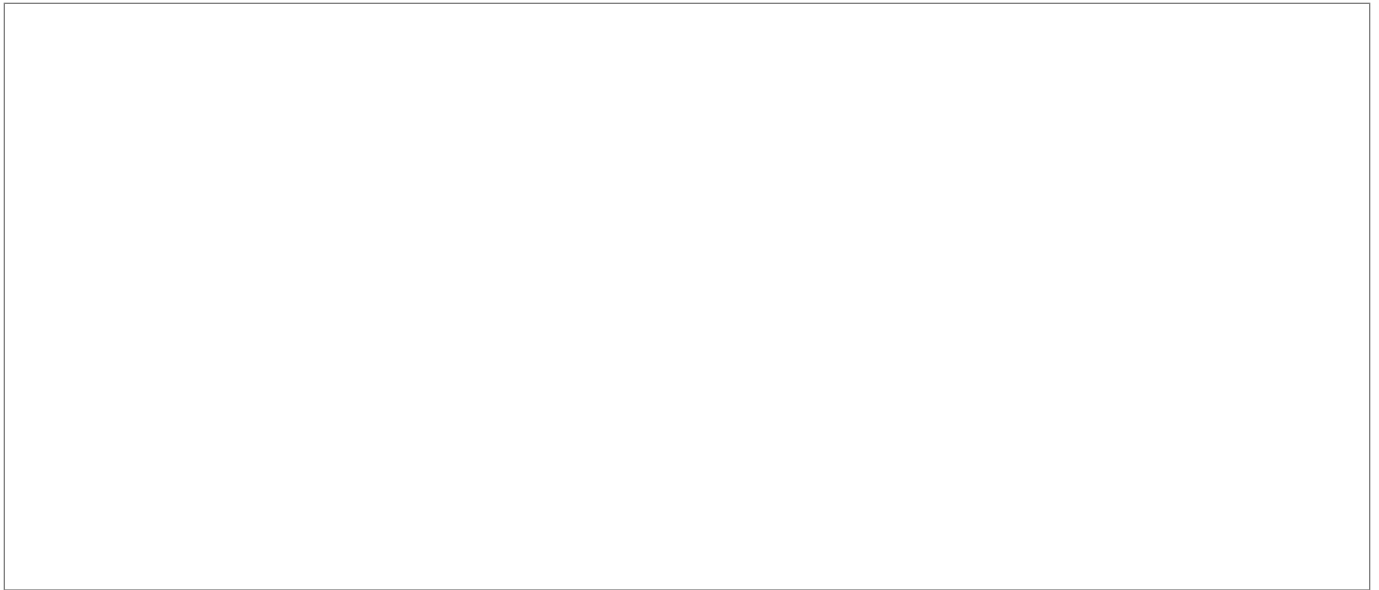
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #22

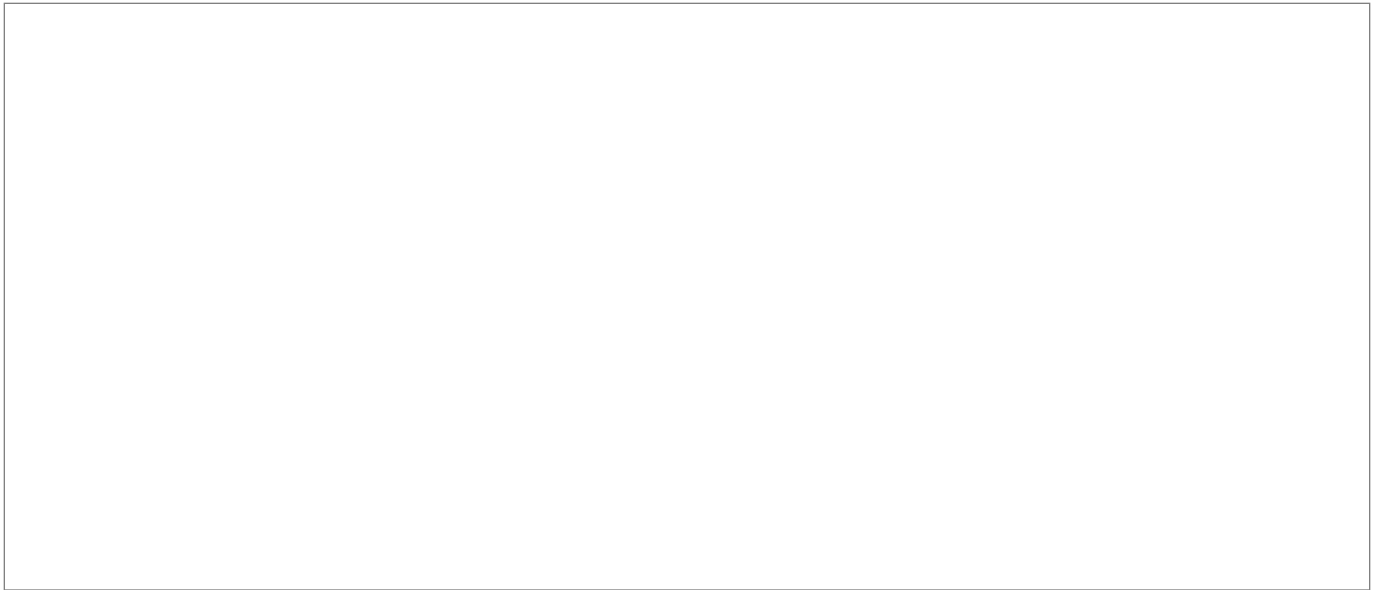
Date: ___/___/___ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp ___ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #23

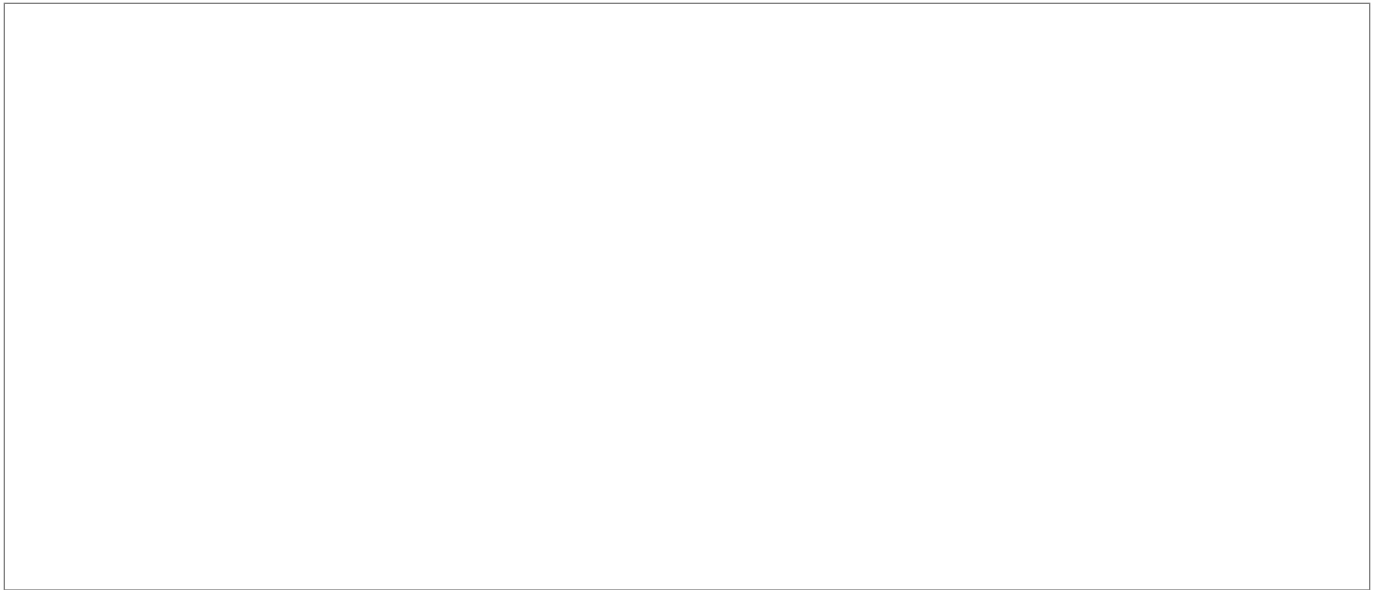
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

NATURE STUDY ENTRY #24

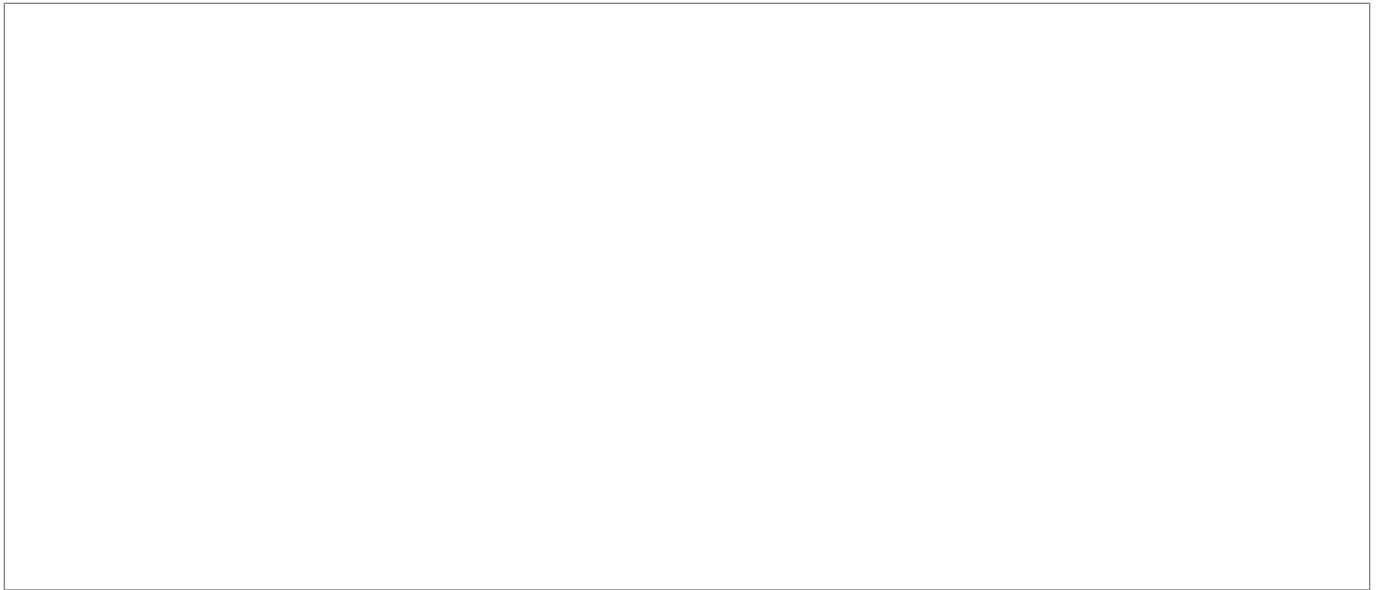
Date: __/__/__ Time: _____ Season: _____

Location: _____

Weather: Temp __ F/C Sky: Clear/Cloudy/Overcast/Rain/Snow Wind: None/Light/Moderate/Strong

WHAT I OBSERVED:

DETAILED SKETCH:



Common Name: _____ Scientific Name: _____

Habitat/Where Found: _____

Colors: _____ Size: _____ Texture: _____

Questions to Research:

BIRD IDENTIFICATION LOG - PAGE 1

[illegible]

BIRD IDENTIFICATION LOG - PAGE 2

[illegible]

PLANT PRESS RECORD

Specimen 1: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 2: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 3: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 4: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 5: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 6: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 7: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 8: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

Specimen 9: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

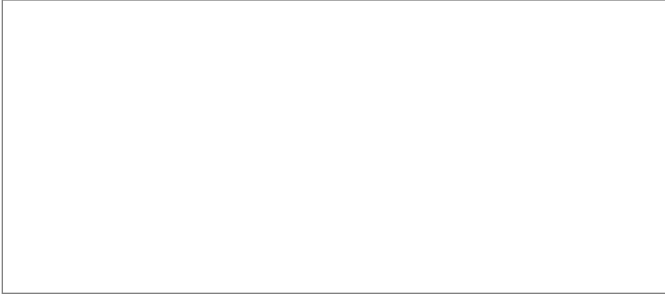
Specimen 10: Name: _____ Date collected: ____/____/____
Location: _____ Habitat: _____
Description: _____

SEASONAL TREE OBSERVATION

Choose ONE tree near your home. Observe and sketch it each season.

My tree: Species _____ Location: _____

SPRING Date: ____/____/____



Leaves: _____

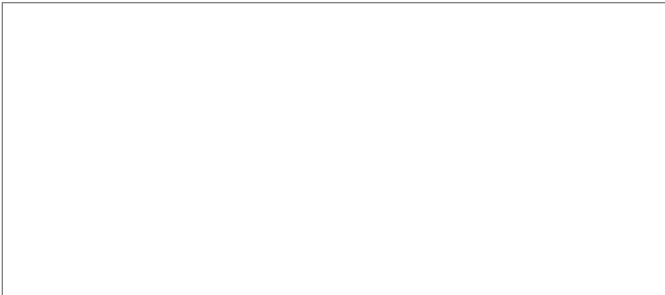
Color: _____

Bark: _____

Visitors: _____

Changes from last season:

SUMMER Date: ____/____/____



Leaves: _____

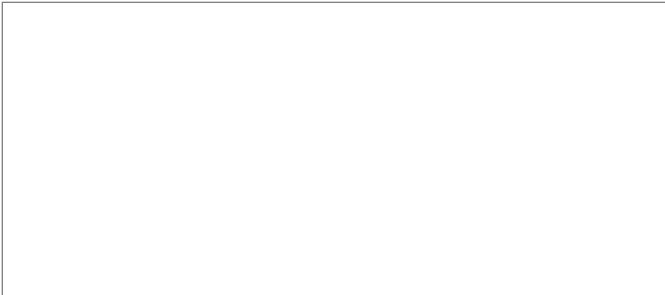
Color: _____

Bark: _____

Visitors: _____

Changes from last season:

FALL Date: ____/____/____



Leaves: _____

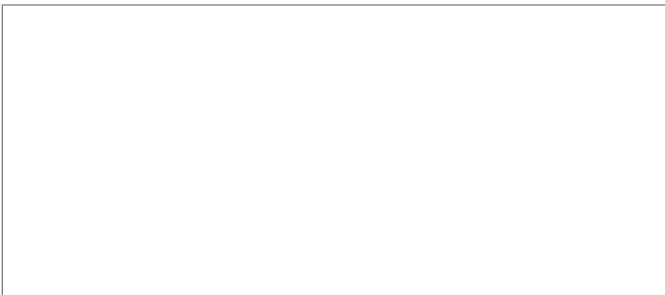
Color: _____

Bark: _____

Visitors: _____

Changes from last season:

WINTER Date: ____/____/____



Leaves: _____

Color: _____

Bark: _____

Visitors: _____

Changes from last season:

NATURE COLLECTION INVENTORY

Record items in your nature collection:

#	Item	Type	Found Where	Date	Notes
1				__/__/__	
2				__/__/__	
3				__/__/__	
4				__/__/__	
5				__/__/__	
6				__/__/__	
7				__/__/__	
8				__/__/__	
9				__/__/__	
10				__/__/__	
11				__/__/__	
12				__/__/__	
13				__/__/__	
14				__/__/__	
15				__/__/__	
16				__/__/__	
17				__/__/__	
18				__/__/__	
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25				__/__/__	
26				__/__/__	
27				__/__/__	
28				__/__/__	
29				__/__/__	
30				__/__/__	
31				__/__/__	
32				__/__/__	
33				__/__/__	
34				__/__/__	
35				__/__/__	

MONTHLY NATURE CHALLENGE CARDS

Complete one challenge each month. Check off when done!

- ☐ **January:** Find 5 different types of animal tracks
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **February:** Observe the same bird for 10 minutes straight
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **March:** Find signs of spring awakening (3 examples)
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **April:** Press and identify 5 different wildflowers
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **May:** Find a bird nest (observe from distance, never touch)
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **June:** Catch and release 3 insects - sketch each one
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **July:** Map all the trees in your yard or block
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **August:** Stargaze - identify 3 constellations
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **September:** Collect 10 different leaf types, identify each
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **October:** Find 3 different types of fungus/mushrooms
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **November:** Sit silently outdoors for 15 minutes, record all sounds
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____

- ☐ **December:** Identify 5 birds at a feeder or in your neighborhood
Date completed: ___/___/___ Notes: _____